

Checklist:

Engineering Career Paths

1. Understand your COMPANY TYPE

- ☐ Identify what **kind of company** you work for or are targeting:
 - ☐ Big Tech
 - ☐ Medium-to-large tech company
 - ☐ Scaleup
 - ☐ Startup
 - ☐ Traditional company with tech division
 - ☐ Technology-heavy traditional company
 - ☐ Small non-venture-funded company
 - ☐ Public sector
 - ☐ Nonprofit
 - ☐ Consultancy/outourcing/agency
 - ☐ Academia or research lab
- ☐ Compare the company type against your goals for **compensation, stability, growth**, impact, and work-life balance.
- ☐ Talk to people who work at **similar companies** to understand the real day-to-day experience.
- ☐ Remember that **team quality** can matter as much as company category.

2. Choose a REALISTIC career path

- ☐ Decide whether you are more interested in a path as an **individual contributor** or in **management**.
- ☐ Learn whether your company has:
 - ☐ A single-track career ladder
 - ☐ A dual-track IC and manager ladder
- ☐ Identify the **highest realistic IC level** at your current company.
- ☐ Check whether **advancement** beyond senior/staff requires moving **into management**.
- ☐ Consider whether you might **switch** between IC and manager tracks over time.

3. Think beyond the “STANDARD” path

- ☐ Consider which career pattern **fits you best**:
 - ☐ Lifelong software engineer
 - ☐ Specialist
 - ☐ Generalist/specialist pendulum
 - ☐ Engineer in a niche field
 - ☐ Contractor or freelancer
 - ☐ Tech lead
 - ☐ Engineering manager
 - ☐ Founder or business owner
 - ☐ Non-software role such as PM, DevRel, TPM, recruiting
 - ☐ Engineer/manager pendulum
 - ☐ Combination path
 - ☐ Non-linear career path
- ☐ Avoid assuming there is **only one** “good” career path.
- ☐ Review examples of people with **non-linear careers**.

4. Understand COMPENSATION tiers

- ☐ Identify whether a company is likely **Tier 1, Tier 2, or Tier 3** for compensation.
- ☐ Compare total compensation, not just salary:
 - ☐ **Base** salary
 - ☐ Cash **bonus**
 - ☐ **Equity**
- ☐ Understand whether **equity** is liquid or illiquid.
- ☐ Be cautious about **private-company equity** that may never become valuable.
- ☐ Compare **compensation** expectations with job **difficulty** and performance **expectations**.

5. Compare TRADEOFFS between tiers

- ☐ For Tier 1 companies, check whether you value **stability**, easier hiring access, or better work-life balance.
- ☐ For Tier 2 companies, check whether you want **stronger pay** with more demanding expectations.
- ☐ For Tier 3 companies, check whether you are prepared for very high **hiring difficulty** and demanding performance standards.
- ☐ Compare expected career **growth**:

- ☐ Can ICs progress beyond **senior**?
- ☐ Can ICs progress beyond **staff**?
- ☐ Are **manager** paths clearer than IC paths?
- ☐ Consider whether the highest pay is worth the **pressure**.

6. EVALUATE profit center vs. cost center

- ☐ Determine whether your team directly generates **revenue**.
- ☐ Ask whether your team's impact is **visible** to executives.
- ☐ Check whether your work supports a **core product**, internal tooling, compliance, infrastructure, or operations.
- ☐ Look at which teams receive **funding**, headcount, and executive **attention**.
- ☐ Assess how your **team's position** affects:
 - ☐ Promotions
 - ☐ Bonuses
 - ☐ Internal transfers
 - ☐ Attrition risk
 - ☐ Job security
- ☐ Learn to succeed in both **profit centers** and **cost centers**.

7. BROADEN how you measure career progress

- ☐ Do not evaluate your career **only by title**, company name, and compensation.
- ☐ Also **evaluate**:
 - ☐ **People** you work with
 - ☐ **Manager** relationship
 - ☐ **Position** within the team and company
 - ☐ Company **culture**
 - ☐ Company **mission**
 - ☐ Professional **growth**
 - ☐ **Mental** and physical health
 - ☐ **Flexibility** of time and place
 - ☐ Ability to **disconnect** from work
 - ☐ **Stress** level
 - ☐ **Life** outside work
 - ☐ Personal **motivation**
- ☐ Decide what **balance** matters most for your current life stage.
- ☐ Revisit your **priorities** before changing jobs.

8. OWN your career development

- ☐ Do not assume your manager will handle your **career progression** for you.
- ☐ Learn what **promotion** and performance expectations are at your company.
- ☐ Ask what **additional activities** are needed for recognition.
- ☐ Make your **impact** visible.
- ☐ Seek regular **feedback**.
- ☐ Build relationships with **peers**, managers, and senior engineers.
- ☐ **Track** accomplishments and outcomes.
- ☐ **Reassess** your path regularly as your goals change.